Proud to be Latina/Latino – A Collection

By Denice Frohman, Maria Luisa Arroyo and Christina Stoddard

INTRODUCTION

Reports of people being berated or attacked while communicating in Spanish, the world's second most spoken language, are on the rise. When people glare at others for speaking Spanish in public, refer to it as a "dirty" language, say "go back to your country" or even, "Speak English. You're in America!" — is it any wonder that some Latinas/Latinos begin to feel ashamed of their language and cultural identity?

Well, I'm here to tell you that Spanish is a beautiful language and the Latino culture is inspiring. I am proud to be Latina/Latino – A collection by Denice Frohman, Maria Luisa Arroyo and Christina Stoddard.

DUCATIONAL

Accents by Denice Frohman

my mom holds her accent like a shotgun,
with two good hands.
her tongue, all brass knuckle
slipping in between her lips
her hips, all laughter and wind clap.

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she speaks a *sanchocho** of spanish and english,
pushing up and against one another,
in rapid fire

there is no telling my mama to be "quiet,"
she don't know "quiet."
her voice is one size better fit all
and you best not tell her to hush,
she waited too many years for her voice to arrive
to be told it needed house keeping.

English sits in her mouth remixed
so "strawberry" becomes "eh-strawbeddy"
and "cookie" becomes "eh-cookie"
and kitchen, key chain, and chicken all sound the same.

my mama doesn't say "yes"
she says, "ah ha"
and suddenly the sky in her mouth becomes a Hector
Lavoe song.

her tongue can't lay itself down flat enough
for the English language,
it got too much hip
too much bone
too much conga

too much *cuatro**
to two step
got too many piano keys
in between her teeth,
it got too much clave
too much hand clap
got too much salsa to sit still
it be an anxious child wanting to
make Play-Doh out of concrete
English be too neat for
her kind of wonderful.
her words spill in conversation
between women whose hands
are all they got
sometimes our hands are all we got
and accents remind us that we are still
*bomba**, still *plena**

say "*wepa**"
and a stranger becomes your *hermano**,
say "*dale**"
and a crowd becomes a family reunion.

my mama's tongue is a telegram from her mother
decorated with the *coqui's** of *el campo**

so even though her lips can barely

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stretch themselves around english,
her accent is a stubborn compass
always pointing her
towards home.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Denice Frohman
Book: Reading, Writing, and Rising Up – 2nd Edition (Pg 248)
ISBN: 978-0942961690
Publisher: Rethinking Schools, Ltd
Date (Month/Year): June 15, 2017

- ***sanchocho*** *- a hearty soup, almost like a stew and is a traditional dish in the region of Antioquia, Colombia that combines potatoes, yuca, corn, plantains and meat*
- ***cuatro*** *– four*
- ***bomba*** *- something that "explodes," or "sprays."*
- ***plena*** *– Full*
- ***wepa*** *- of Puerto Rican descent, this exclamation is mainly used when something is to be celebrated and always yelled…the meaning is similar to "Oh yeah!" "Cool!" or "Go for it!" etc.*
- ***hermano*** *– brother*
- ***dale*** *– go ahead*
- ***coqui*** *– small amphibian with a shrill call*
- ***el campo*** *– a city in Texas*

TIONAL USE ON

Gathering Words by Maria Luisa Arroyo

One day I will write you a letter
after I have gathered enough words
I have heard
pop! pop! pop!
like little soap bubbles escaping
the animated mouths
of the women who share
pieces of gossip like *bombones**
in *la lavandería** every Sunday

One day I will write you a letter
after I have gathered enough words
that blossom without thorns
in painted mouths, in someone else's countries…
In my corner, I listen to how voices ring
without the sting of *bofetadas**
and how they undulate above
gushing water and swirling clothes
in machines that vibrate in *la lavandería*

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One day, I will write you a letter
after I have gathered enough words
and enough courage
to let them ring in my mute dreams
until they sing to me: Write us. *Así**.
In your childhood tongue. *Recóbranos**. Recover us.
At that time, I will be able to return without fear
to *la lavandería* with my bags of clothes
and enough words and surrender myself to the bubbles.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Maria Luisa Arroyo
ISBN: 978-1931010436
Publisher: Bilingual Review Pr
Date (Month/Year): June 2008

- ***bombones*** *- chocolates*
- ***la lavandería*** *- laundry*
- ***bofetadas*** *- slapping*
- ***Así*** *- Yes*
- ***Recóbranos*** *- Recover*

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Postcards to Heaven by Christina Stoddard

Mami taught kindergarten at the Catholic school
at the end of our long and dusty road.
Because of this, her serpentine handwriting
was as perfectly beautiful as her slender fingers.

On Saturdays, *Mami* sat at our dinner table
and stared at the mini cactus centerpiece
until the scrambled words in her mind
found the order of filed school children
eager to drink from the water fountain
on a fiery desert afternoon in June.

Then she wrote.

"Querida Madre."*
"Querida Mamá."*
"Querida Mami."*

Her mood dictated the greeting,
Not that I ever gleaned
more of her message.

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*Mami me dijo que**
the postcards were for Abuela*,
not me, the little nosy one.

Sometimes she spread postcards
out on the table and
invited me to craft a message.
She tried to entice me with
pretty pictures and
glittery gel pens.

But I never followed her siren call.
I had no words for *Abuela*,
at least none suitable for a postcard.

What would I write?

"Querida Abuela, I resent you.
You have robbed too much of
my mother's love for me.
I wish you were alive so
I would never have to
visit your ugly grave again."

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How do you sign off a postcard like that?

"Love?" "Hugs?" "Sincerely?"

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Christina Stoddard
Book: Water for the Cactus Woman (pg 38)
ISBN: 978-1947980273
Publisher: Spuyten Duyvil Publishing
Date (Month/Year): April 13, 2018

- ***Querida Madre*** – Dear Mother
- ***Querida Mamá*** – Dear Mom
- ***Querida Mami*** – Dear Mommy
- ***Mami me dijo que*** - Mommy told me that
- ***Abuela*** – Grandma
- ***Querida Abuela*** – Dear Grandma

AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier

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